# Somber Journal: Videos 3 & 4

Scripts, script prompts, packaging and channel branding for the editor

1. **Overview**
   - How to use this pack
   - Notes
2. **Video 3: What Your Family Stops Telling You at Every Level of Wealth**
   - Packaging
   - Script
   - Script prompt
3. **Video 4: What Losing Everything Looks Like, Level by Level**
   - Packaging
   - Script
   - Script prompt
4. **Channel branding: Somber Journal**
   - Name and handle
   - Tagline (banner, description, end of every video description)
   - Channel description: final (recommended)
   - Channel description: short version (About preview, social bios)
   - Video description template (paste under every upload)
   - Channel keywords (YouTube Studio → Settings → Channel → Keywords)
   - Logo prompt: Option 1, the journal (recommended)
   - Logo prompt: Option 2, monogram
   - Banner prompts (v2, built on your existing character and wordmark)
   - Video watermark (YouTube Studio → Customization → Branding)
   - Brand palette
   - Switching checklist

# 1. Overview

## How to use this pack

- **Section 1** is release order and the general notes.
- **Each video section** has the packaging (titles, thumbnail, Shorts), the full voiceover script, and the AI script prompt.
- In the scripts, **level headings** are spoken aloud as written, and the **shaded "Rule" lines** end each level. Good places for text on screen.
- Each script ends with a **closing question** for the viewer. Show it on screen as well as speaking it, to drive comments.
- Both scripts are about 16–17 minutes at 150 words per minute.

## Notes

Both scripts follow `landlord-video/master-script-prompt.md` (Format A, Level Ladder), ~2,400 words, ~16 min.

**Release order.** Publish Video 3 first. It's the closest fit to the viral pattern found across all three transcripts (people and family as the measure, distance as the cost). Publish Video 4 3–4 days later. Keep the title and thumbnail style consistent with Video 2, which got 7% CTR.

# 2. Video 3: What Your Family Stops Telling You at Every Level of Wealth

## Packaging

POV Finance already has "How Your Family Treats You at Every Level of Wealth", so don't use that title. This angle is "what they stop telling you": the script's real payoff is the family going quiet as you get richer (the graduation you found out about from a photo, the surgery you heard about afterwards).

**Title options**

1. What Your Family Stops Telling You at Every Level of Wealth
2. You Became the Rich One in Your Family. Here's What Changed at Every Level
3. You and Your Brother at Every Level of Wealth

**Thumbnail:** a long Thanksgiving table seen from above. One cartoon figure sits on a rusty metal folding chair by the kitchen door, and the same figure sits alone in a velvet chair at the far head, with the family turned away. Text: "−$3,140 → $10M".

**Same tests at every level:** where you sit at Thanksgiving, Mom's 4:10 Sunday call ("Are you eating?"), the family group chat, the loan requests, brother Marcus.

**Shorts to cut (30–45 s each)**

- "Rule one... you're a warning they give the cousins"
- The furnace call: "I didn't want to bother your brother"
- "A family will never tell you that you've been promoted. They'll just move the furniture."
- Ending: the foil plate, "For later. Eat."

**Pinned comment question:** "What changed about how your family treated you when your money changed?"

## Script

*Target: 2,450 words · Final: 2,607 words · est. runtime 17.4 min*

## Level one, negative $3,140

That's the number on the screen when your mother calls. A credit card at 27.9%. A payday advance you swore you'd never take. A phone that is three weeks from being shut off. She calls on a Sunday at 4:10, the way she always does, and the first thing she says isn't hello. It's "Are you eating?" You say yes. You're standing in a gas station holding a $2.19 hot dog. You tell her it's pasta.

Thanksgiving is in eleven days. You already know where you'll sit. There's a folding chair at the end of your aunt Denise's table, the metal one with the rubber foot missing, the one that rocks when you lean back. It sits next to the kitchen door, so every time someone needs more gravy, they squeeze past your shoulder. You've sat in it since you were nine. You're twenty-six.

Your brother Marcus sits in the middle. Marcus is a pharmacist. Marcus has a mortgage, a fiancée named Brielle, and a car that doesn't make a sound when it starts. Nobody asks Marcus how he's doing. They ask him what he thinks.

At dinner, your uncle Ray asks what you're doing for work now. Not "how's work." What are you doing now. As if the answer changes every time he asks, and it does. You say warehouse, nights. He nods slowly, the way people nod at weather. Your aunt says, "Well, that's honest work," and the table goes quiet for one second too long, and someone passes the rolls, and that second is the whole verdict, and you will hear it on the drive home, and on the drive home after that, and every Thanksgiving until something changes.

After dinner, the women pack leftovers into margarine tubs and hand them out at the door. Marcus gets the turkey. Ray gets the pie. You get a tub of green beans, pressed into your hands by your mother with both of hers, held a second longer than necessary. She doesn't say anything. She doesn't have to. Leftovers are how your family says what it can't say at the table. And what they're saying to you is: we know.

In the family group chat, you don't talk. You react. A heart on the baby photo. A laughing face on Ray's joke. You've learned that typing a full sentence invites a follow-up question, and the follow-up question is always about money.

Here's the part nobody says out loud at the table. Families don't rank you by how much you love them. They rank you by how much they worry about you. And worry, at this level, looks exactly like distance.

What nobody tells you: Marcus got engaged in August. You find out tonight, months late. Nobody mentions good news around you. At this level, silence is pity.

> **Rule one. At negative $3,140, you're not family. You're a warning they give the cousins.**

## Level two, $900

It took you seven months to get here. You paid off the payday loan. You stopped buying the hot dog. You kept the phone. $900 doesn't sound like much, but it's the first number in years without a minus sign, and you check it the way you'd check a sleeping baby.

Your mother can hear it. You don't know how. You haven't told her. But on the Sunday call, at 4:10, she doesn't ask if you're eating. She asks if you're "doing okay now." The word "now" is new. It means she's noticed something. It also means she's waiting to see if it lasts.

Christmas, same house. Same folding chair. But Denise hands you a plate before anyone else, which has never happened, and you don't know what to do with it, so you just say thank you too many times.

Marcus pulls you aside by the coat rack. He says he's proud of you. He means it. He also says, "Just don't blow it this time," and he means that too, and you realize your brother has been carrying a version of you in his head for a decade, and that version keeps losing.

Nobody asks you for anything at $900. Nobody offers you anything either. You're on probation. A family doesn't trust a recovery until it's had a few holidays to prove itself.

What nobody tells you: Marcus offered to co-sign a car loan for you. Your mother told him, not yet. At this level, silence is caution.

> **Rule two. At $900, you're not family. You're a question they haven't finished asking.**

## Level three, $8,000

You got the day shift. Then the lead position. Then a raise to $21.40 an hour, which you read three times in the break room because it didn't feel like a number that belonged to you. $8,000 in savings. An emergency fund, the internet calls it. You call it the first time you've slept through the night since college.

The first request comes in March. Your cousin Tasha. A text at 11:52 p.m. She hates to ask. Her car's transmission. $1,400. She'll pay you back by May. You stare at the screen. Nobody has ever asked you for money before. Nobody thought you had any.

You send it. It feels good. That's the part that surprises you. It feels like being picked for a team.

By May, Tasha doesn't mention it. By July, she posts photos from a beach in Gulf Shores. You don't say anything. You just notice that you noticed. Not anger. Just arithmetic.

At Thanksgiving, you're still in the folding chair. But Uncle Ray says, "Heard you're management now," and he says it to the whole table, like he's announcing it, like he discovered it. Your mother looks down at her plate and smiles in a way you haven't seen since you were small.

The money didn't make them love you more. It made them stop flinching when they looked at you. And for a while, those feel like the same thing.

What nobody tells you: two days later, Ray called your mother to ask whether you'd lend to him too. At this level, silence is strategy.

> **Rule three. At $8,000, you're not family. You're an option.**

## Level four, $40,000

You start a side business. Small. Commercial cleaning contracts, two offices, then six, then a dental chain with nine locations. You hire your first employee. Then four more. The savings account crosses $40,000 on a Tuesday morning, and you're sitting in your car outside a dentist's office at 5:30 a.m. with a mop bucket in the back seat, and you laugh out loud alone.

Your mother's furnace dies in January. She doesn't call Marcus. She calls you. You notice that. She says it so quietly you almost miss it. "I didn't want to bother your brother. He's got the wedding." The furnace is $6,850. You pay it the same afternoon. She cries on the phone, and then she apologizes for crying, and then she asks if you're eating, and this time you tell her the truth. Yes. Actually, yes.

Marcus finds out from Denise. He calls you that night. He says he would have helped. You believe him. You also hear something underneath it, a small scrape of metal, the sound of a chair being moved in his head.

At Thanksgiving, Denise takes the folding chair away. Not to the garage. She gives it to Tasha's boyfriend. You sit at the long side of the table now, two seats from the middle. Nobody says anything about it. Nobody has to. A family will never tell you that you've been promoted. They'll just move the furniture.

What nobody tells you: Marcus's wedding is $11,000 short. Brielle's parents cover it. He'd rather owe them than owe you. At this level, silence is pride.

> **Rule four. At $40,000, you're not family. You're the backup plan.**

## Level five, $250,000

Eleven contracts. Thirty-one employees. A profit last year of $412,000, and $250,000 of it sitting in an account you still can't look at without your chest getting tight. You bought a house. Not big. But it has a guest room, and the guest room, it turns out, is the most expensive thing you own.

Because people start using it. Uncle Ray stays for a week in April. He has a business idea. Gourmet food trucks. He needs a partner, and by partner he means $60,000. You say you'll think about it. He says, "Family helps family," and he says it at breakfast, in your kitchen, eating your eggs.

The group chat changes. You're tagged in things now. Fundraisers. A cousin's GoFundMe. A screenshot of a car someone's thinking about buying, with the caption, "What do you think?" They're not asking what you think. You know what they're asking.

Your mother still calls at 4:10 on Sundays. But now she rehearses. You can hear it. A little pause before she brings anything up, like she's checking whether she's allowed. She used to tell you about her week. Now she tells you about other people's problems, and then she waits.

And here's the part that's hard to admit. You like it. Not the asking. The being asked. For the first time in your life, people need you more than they worry about you, and it feels like oxygen, and you hate that it feels like oxygen, and you say yes to $4,000 for Tasha's rent and $2,500 for Ray's permit fees and $900 for a cousin you've met twice, and every yes buys you an hour of feeling like the middle of the table.

Then Marcus loses his job. The pharmacy chain closes forty stores in one week. He doesn't call you. You find out from Brielle. You call him. He doesn't pick up. He texts back: "I'm fine. Don't." Just that. Don't.

The person who carried a losing version of you for ten years can't carry a losing version of himself for one week.

What nobody tells you: in March, there was a dinner at Denise's. You weren't invited. They decided who would ask you for what, and in what order. At this level, silence is a plan.

> **Rule five. At $250,000, you're not family. You're the bank. And banks don't get phone calls on Sundays. They get requests.**

## Level six, $1.2 million

The company sells a minority stake to a private equity group out of Charlotte. You sign the papers in a conference room with a view of a parking garage. Your share is $1.2 million after taxes. You drive home and sit in the driveway for forty minutes with the engine off.

Thanksgiving moves to your house. Nobody votes on it. It just happens. Denise calls in October and says, "So, we'll do it at yours this year," and it isn't a question. You buy a table that seats sixteen.

And at the head of it, there's a chair. A real one. Upholstered. Your mother pulls it out for you before dinner, and the whole family watches you sit in it, and you realize something terrible. You don't want it. You want the folding chair. Not the chair. The person you were in it. The person nobody needed anything from.

Conversations stop when you walk into the kitchen. Not dramatically. They just get quieter. Somebody changes the subject to the weather. Your cousins' kids call you "Uncle" or "Auntie" in a voice their parents taught them. Polite. Careful. The voice you use for people who might give you something.

Marcus comes. He's working again, a hospital pharmacy, less money than before. He sits in the middle seat, the one that used to be his whole personality. He's quiet all night. When he leaves, he hugs you at the door and says, "You did good." Then, softer, "I don't know how to talk to you anymore." You don't know how to answer. So you don't.

Your mother calls at 4:10 on Sunday. She asks, "Is this a good time?" She has never asked that before. In your entire life, it was always a good time.

What nobody tells you: Marcus has been seeing a therapist since the layoff. Everyone knows but you. At this level, silence is distance.

> **Rule six. At $1.2 million, you're not family. You're the story they tell at other people's tables.**

## Level seven, $10 million

The second sale. The full company. A national facilities firm buys everything, the contracts, the trucks, the name you painted on the first van yourself. You become a number that gets written about in a regional business journal. Ray prints the article and frames it. It hangs in his hallway, next to his own wedding photo.

Nobody asks if you're eating anymore. Nobody asks how you are. They ask how business is, even though there is no business. They ask about the market. They ask what you think about interest rates, the way they used to ask Marcus what he thought.

The requests stop, too. That's the strange part. At $10 million, people stop asking for $1,400. They're ashamed to. The number is so big it makes small needs feel insulting. So they stop telling you about their small needs. Which means they stop telling you about their lives.

You try to fix it. You fly everyone to a rented house in the Smoky Mountains for a week in July. Twenty-two people. A hot tub, a fire pit, a chef who comes in the evenings. It's beautiful. Everyone says thank you. And every night, around the fire pit, the stories are about the old days, the warehouse, the folding chair, the time you showed up to Easter in a borrowed tie. They tell them warmly. They tell them like a eulogy.

Tasha's daughter graduates. You find out from a photo. Denise has a surgery. You find out after. Not because they're hiding it. Because somewhere along the line, they decided you were too busy for the small things. And the small things, it turns out, were the family. At this level, nobody tells you anything, because nobody thinks you need anything. Silence is what they think respect looks like.

At Thanksgiving, you sit at the head of a table you paid for, in a house you paid for, surrounded by people whose rent you've paid, and you can't remember the last time anyone told you a joke that wasn't for your benefit.

After dinner, everyone leaves. You're carrying plates to the kitchen when you see it. Your mother has saved you a plate, wrapped in foil, the way she did when you worked nights at the warehouse. On top, in her handwriting, on a strip of masking tape: "For later. Eat."

You stand in the kitchen and hold it for a long time.

> **Rule seven. At $10 million, you're not family. You're a stranger they're proud of. And pride is what love turns into when it doesn't know what to say.**

## Outro

Somewhere tonight, someone is sitting in a folding chair. Metal. One rubber foot missing. It rocks when they lean back. It's next to the kitchen door, and every time someone needs more gravy, they squeeze past their shoulder. Their uncle just asked what they're doing for work now. The table went quiet for one second too long. Someone passed the rolls.

They think if they just had more, they'd finally be seen. And they're right. They will be. That's the part nobody warns you about.

Your family doesn't love you more at every level. They don't love you less. They just slowly forget which version of you they're supposed to be loving.

## Closing question (voiceover + on-screen text)

**What's one thing your family stopped telling you when your money changed? Tell me in the comments. I read every one.**

## Script prompt

Copy everything below the divider line and paste it into any AI. To get a fresh variation, change the names, numbers and settings in the INPUTS block.

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You are a scriptwriter for Somber Journal, a faceless YouTube channel that tells money stories in 2D animation. The channel is about how money quietly changes the way people treat you. It gives no financial advice and no how-to steps. Write ONE complete, original, voiceover-ready script.

### INPUTS

- Title: What Your Family Stops Telling You at Every Level of Wealth
- Format: Level Ladder, 7 levels
- Target length: 2,450 words (stay within ±5%), about 16 minutes at 150 wpm
- Levels: −$3,140 · $900 · $8,000 · $40,000 · $250,000 · $1.2 million · $10 million
- How the money grows: warehouse night shift → day-shift lead → a commercial cleaning side business → company sells a minority stake → full sale
- Cast (first names only; the protagonist is never named and never gendered):
  - Mom: calls every Sunday at 4:10 and always opens with "Are you eating?"
  - Marcus: older brother, a pharmacist, starts as the family success, later loses his job; fiancée Brielle
  - Aunt Denise: hosts Thanksgiving
  - Uncle Ray: asks "what are you doing for work now", later pitches business ideas
  - Cousin Tasha: the first person to ask you for money

### CORE IDEA

As your money rises, your family doesn't love you more or less. They change what they tell you. At the bottom they hide good news out of pity. At the top they hide their lives because they think you no longer need anything. The cost of wealth is being slowly left out of your own family.

## SAME TESTS AT EVERY LEVEL (RE-RUN ALL OF THESE AT EVERY LEVEL SO THE CHANGE IS FELT, NOT TOLD)

1. Where you sit at Thanksgiving. It starts on a metal folding chair with one rubber foot missing, next to the kitchen door. Then you're handed a plate first, then moved to the long side of the table, then the dinner moves to your house, then you're at the head in an upholstered chair.
2. Mom's 4:10 Sunday call and how her opening line changes: "Are you eating?" → "Are you doing okay now?" → she rehearses before asking → "Is this a good time?" → she stops asking how you are.
3. The family group chat: you only react with emojis → you're tagged in fundraisers and "what do you think?" screenshots → you hear about events from photos.
4. Money requests: none → Tasha's $1,400 she never repays → the furnace → Ray's $60,000 partnership → nobody asks at all because small needs feel insulting.
5. Marcus: proud but doubting ("Just don't blow it this time") → hurt that Mom called you, not him → "I'm fine. Don't." after his layoff → "I don't know how to talk to you anymore."

## REQUIRED BEAT AT EVERY LEVEL: "WHAT NOBODY TELLS YOU"

Just before each level's Rule line, add 1–2 sentences that reveal one thing the family kept from you, then name the silence with "At this level, silence is ___." Use this progression:

- −$3,140: Marcus got engaged months ago and nobody mentions good news around you. Silence is pity.
- $900: Marcus offered to co-sign a loan for you and Mom said "not yet". Silence is caution.
- $8,000: Ray called Mom to ask if you'd lend to him too. Silence is strategy.
- $40,000: Marcus's wedding was $11,000 short and his in-laws covered it. He'd rather owe them than you. Silence is pride.
- $250,000: there was a family dinner you weren't invited to, where they planned who would ask you for what. Silence is a plan.
- $1.2M: Marcus has been in therapy since the layoff and everyone knows but you. Silence is distance.
- $10M: nobody tells you anything because they think you need nothing. Silence is what they think respect looks like.

## LEVEL BLUEPRINT

- Level 1, −$3,140: a gas-station hot dog you call pasta, the folding chair, Ray's question and the second of silence that's "the whole verdict", leftovers pressed into your hands

("we know"). Thesis line within the first 250 words: families rank you by how much they worry about you, and worry looks like distance. Rule: "you're a warning they give the cousins."

- Level 2, $900: the first number without a minus sign, Mom adds the word "now", Denise hands you a plate first, Marcus's "just don't blow it". Rule: "a question they haven't finished asking."
- Level 3, $8,000: a raise to $21.40 an hour, Tasha's 11:52 p.m. text asking for $1,400, the good feeling of being "picked for a team", her beach photos in July, Ray announcing "management" to the table. Rule: "an option."
- Level 4, $40,000: the cleaning business takes off, Mom's $6,850 furnace ("I didn't want to bother your brother"), you finally tell her the truth that you're eating, Denise gives the folding chair away ("A family will never tell you that you've been promoted. They'll just move the furniture."). Rule: "the backup plan."
- Level 5, $250,000: a guest room that becomes the most expensive thing you own, Ray's "family helps family" pitch over your eggs. Include the moral discomfort: you like being asked, "it feels like oxygen". Marcus loses his job and texts "I'm fine. Don't." Rule: "the bank. And banks don't get phone calls on Sundays. They get requests."
- Level 6, $1.2M: Thanksgiving moves to your house without a vote, the upholstered chair at the head, and you wishing for the folding chair, meaning the person you were in it. Kids taught to speak to you politely. Marcus: "I don't know how to talk to you anymore." Mom: "Is this a good time?" Rule: "the story they tell at other people's tables."
- Level 7, $10M: Ray frames a business article about you, people ask about interest rates instead of you, the requests stop. A rented Smoky Mountains house where the old stories are told "like a eulogy". Tasha's daughter's graduation and Denise's surgery found out late. Final scene: Mom has saved you a foil-wrapped plate with masking tape that reads "For later. Eat." Rule: "a stranger they're proud of. And pride is what love turns into when it doesn't know what to say."

## OUTRO

"Somewhere tonight..." replays Level 1 in third person with a stranger in the folding chair: the rocking leg, the gravy squeeze, Ray's question, the passed rolls. Then close on one thesis line, in this spirit: "Your family doesn't love you more at every level. They don't love you less. They just slowly forget which version of you they're supposed to be loving."

## VOICE AND STYLE

- Second person, present tense, 100% of the time. The protagonist is never named. Supporting characters always get first names.

- The narrator is calm, intimate and slightly clinical. Warm toward people, never mocking the family: they are flawed, not villains.
- Name the missing or unexpected feeling, never the obvious one ("Not anger. Just arithmetic.").
- Mostly short sentences of 4–10 words and fragments. Every 5–7 lines, add one long cascading sentence of 25–40 words joined with "and..., and..., and...".
- Use negation runs ("Not X. Not Y. Just Z."). End most paragraphs on a 3–6 word punch.
- Numbers are always exact and slightly odd ($2.19, $6,850, 11:52 p.m.).
- Drop a quotable line every 150–230 words that could stand alone as a clip.
- Each level ends with the spoken verdict: "Rule [N]. At $[amount], you're not family. You're ___."
- Include at least one tender, unspoken-love moment and at least one moment where the protagonist notices something ugly in themselves.
- The ONLY direct question to the viewer is the closing comment question (see OUTPUT). No intro, no "welcome back", no channel name, no call to subscribe, no advice, no headings, no emojis, no scene directions.

## OUTPUT

1. First line: "TARGET: 2,450 words".
2. The full script as plain paragraphs, voiceover-ready.
3. After the final thesis line, end with this exact closing comment question as its own paragraph: "What's one thing your family stopped telling you when your money changed? Tell me in the comments. I read every one."
4. Last line: "FINAL: [N] words · est. runtime [N/150] min".

# 3. Video 4: What Losing Everything Looks Like, Level by Level

## Packaging

**Title options**

1. What Losing Everything Looks Like, Level by Level
2. From $3.8 Million to $0: What Leaves First
3. How Life Treats You at Every Level of Losing Money

**Thumbnail:** a steel key ring held in a hand. Six keys are falling away in a blur and one cheap silver key is left. Dark background. Text: "$3.8M → $0".

**Recurring motifs:** the key ring (seven keys, one removed per level), the booth at Marlow's and its host, Nora's water filter, Hector.

**Shorts to cut (30–45 s each)**

- "Money doesn't leave all at once. It leaves in the order you stopped paying attention."
- Hector: "You'll be all right, boss."
- "There is always pressure in 'no pressure.'"
- Ending: "Are we poor now?" and the water filter

**Pinned comment question:** "What did losing money teach you that having it never did?"

## Script

*Target: 2,450 words · Final: 2,414 words · est. runtime 16.1 min*

### Level one, $3.8 million

You can feel it in your pocket. Not the money. The keys. Seven of them on a steel ring that weighs more than your phone. The office. The warehouse. The house on Linden Court. The lake place. The boat. The Range Rover. The little brass one for the safe in the closet you've opened twice. When you sit down, they press into your leg, and you like that. It's the only part of the money you can actually touch.

It's 8:14 on a Thursday night at Marlow's, the steakhouse downtown, and the host says your name before you say it. "Your table's ready." He doesn't look at a list. There is no list for you. There's just the corner booth under the brass lamp, and a glass of the wine you ordered once, eight months ago, already poured.

Your phone buzzes twice during dinner. A friend from the club wants to know if you're in for a golf trip to Scottsdale. Your banker, Graham, wants to grab lunch next week, "just to catch up." People don't call you with problems. They call you with plans.

You own Kessler Freight. Forty-two trucks. Ninety-one employees. One client, a national home-goods retailer, accounts for 64% of your revenue, and every advisor you've ever had has told you that number is dangerous, and every year it's grown anyway, because it's easy, and easy pays.

Your wife, Elena, is across the table telling you about your daughter's science fair. Nora is eleven. She built a water filter out of a two-liter bottle and sand. You nod. You're checking the score of a game. Elena notices. She always notices.

Here's what nobody prints on the balance sheet. Money doesn't leave all at once. It leaves in the order you stopped paying attention.

> **Rule one. At $3.8 million, you don't have money. You have momentum. And momentum feels exactly like safety until it stops.**

## Level two, $900,000

The email arrives at 6:02 on a Monday morning. Subject line: "Strategic Vendor Consolidation." The retailer is moving all freight in your region to a national carrier. Ninety days' notice. It's polite. It thanks you for eleven years of partnership. It is four paragraphs long, and it ends 64% of your company.

You do the math in the shower. Then again in the car. Then again on a whiteboard in the office, alone, with the door shut. Forty-two trucks on lease. A line of credit you personally guaranteed, because the bank asked, and back then guaranteeing it felt like signing a birthday card.

You sell the boat first. It doesn't feel like losing. It feels like trimming. $118,000, and a buyer from Ohio who shakes your hand too long. That night, you take the boat key off the ring and set it on the kitchen counter, and it makes a sound so small you almost don't hear it.

You lay off twenty-two drivers in one afternoon. You do it yourself, in the break room, because you think that's what a good owner does. One of them, Hector, has been with you since the second truck. He doesn't argue. He just says, "You'll be all right, boss." And the way he says it, kind, certain, worried about you, is the worst thing anyone says to you all year.

Graham still calls. But now it's not lunch. It's a "review." His voice is friendly in the way a doctor's voice is friendly before the results.

The review happens in a glass room on the ninth floor. Graham has a printout. He has a second man with him, younger, who doesn't introduce himself and doesn't need to. Graham slides the paper across the table and points to a line with a pen he doesn't click. "Covenant ratio." You know what it means. You've known since the shower. He says the bank "values the relationship." He says it twice. The second time, the younger man writes something down.

You drive home and sit in the garage with the engine off. Through the door, you can hear Nora practicing the clarinet. The same four bars, over and over, a note cracking in the same place every time. You used to find it annoying. Tonight you sit in the car and listen to all of it, and you don't go in until she stops, because you don't know what your face looks like.

At dinner, Elena asks how the meeting went. You say, "Fine. Paperwork." She passes you the salt you didn't ask for. It's how she tells you she knows you're lying.

> **Rule two. At $900,000, you didn't lose money. You lost the right to be careless.**

## Level three, $210,000

The line of credit gets called in August. The bank doesn't yell. Banks never yell. They send a letter with the word "regrettably" in the second sentence. $1.4 million due in sixty days. The personal guarantee means the lake house is no longer yours. It's theirs, with your name still on the mailbox.

You sell it in October to a dentist and his husband from Atlanta. They're excited. They ask if the dock lights are on a timer. You tell them yes, 7 p.m., and you don't tell them that's the time Nora used to run down to the water to watch them turn on. You take the lake key off the ring.

At Marlow's, the host still says your name. But the booth under the brass lamp is taken. "We've got a lovely table by the window." It's a fine table. It's just not yours. You notice that you notice.

The Scottsdale golf trip happens without you. You see the photos. Nobody meant anything by it. You'd stopped answering the group text, and the group text stopped waiting.

Here's the part that surprises you. People don't abandon you when you start losing. They just stop including you, quietly, the way you'd stop setting a place for someone who keeps not showing up. And you weren't showing up. You were in the office until midnight, staring at a whiteboard.

Your friend Brent calls once in November. Not about golf. He's heard. Everyone's heard. He says he has a guy, a turnaround consultant, very discreet, $450 an hour. He says it the way people recommend a dermatologist. Then he asks if you and Elena are still coming to the holiday party at the club, and there's a pause after the question, a small one, and you understand that the pause is the real question. You say you'll try. He says, "No pressure." There is always pressure in "no pressure."

You let the club membership lapse in December. $14,800 a year. Nobody calls to ask why.

Elena asks you, in bed, how bad it is. You say it's handled. She doesn't believe you. She doesn't say so. She just turns off the lamp, and the dark feels different than it used to.

> **Rule three. At $210,000, you're not rich and you're not broke. You're the person everyone's waiting to hear about.**

## Level four, $38,000

The company closes in March. Not bankruptcy, not yet. Just closed. The last eleven trucks go back to the leasing company on a Saturday morning. You stand in the empty yard and watch a flatbed haul away a truck with your last name painted on the door, and the paint catches the sun as it turns onto the highway, and you think about the day you painted the first one yourself, in your father's driveway, with a brush from the hardware store and a stencil you cut out of a cereal box.

You take the office key and the warehouse key off the ring. Four keys left.

The Range Rover goes next. The payment was $1,940 a month, a number you never looked at when money was momentum. You buy a nine-year-old Camry for $7,300 cash. The seat has a burn mark. Nora asks if it's a rental. You say no. She says, "Oh." Just that. Oh.

At Marlow's, you go once, alone, out of habit. The host is new. He asks for your name. You give it to him. He looks at the list. "Do you have a reservation?" You don't. You leave before he finds you a table, and in the parking lot you realize you never knew the old host's name either. He knew yours for six years. You never asked.

Your father calls. He's seventy-four. He heard from your cousin. He doesn't ask what happened. He asks if you need the truck. His truck. A 2004 Silverado with 280,000 miles and a tape deck. You say no. He says, "Well, it's there." And then he talks about the weather for twenty minutes, and you realize he's not filling silence. He's keeping you company.

Two weeks later, you see Hector at a gas station on Route 31. He's driving for another company now, a white cab with a blue stripe. He sees you before you can pretend you didn't see him. He walks over, shakes your hand with both of his, and asks about Nora by name.

He asks about Elena. He asks about your father's knee, which you'd mentioned once, four years ago, in the yard. He doesn't ask about the money. Not once. When he leaves, he says, "You still got my number, boss." You realize he's offering you something. Not a job. A place.

> **Rule four. At $38,000, you find out who was calling the money, and who was calling you.**

## Level five, $4,600

The house on Linden Court sells in June. The market's soft. After the bank takes its share and the lawyers take theirs, there's almost nothing. You move into a two-bedroom rental on the east side. Beige carpet. A ceiling fan that ticks on medium. Nora gets the bigger bedroom. You told her it was because she has more stuff. It's because you can't sleep anyway.

You take the Linden Court key off the ring. Two left. The brass safe key, for a safe that's now empty and sitting in a storage unit. And the key to the rental, which is silver, cheap, and cut so roughly it snags on your pocket lining.

You apply for jobs. Operations manager. Logistics director. Your résumé says you ran a company with ninety-one employees. The interviewers read it, look up at you, and you watch them try to figure out what went wrong. Not with the company. With you. One of them asks, carefully, "And why are you looking for a role like this now?" You've rehearsed the answer. It doesn't matter. The question was the answer.

You start doing math nobody taught you. Groceries for three, $164 a week if you're careful. The rental, $1,525. The Camry's insurance, $112. Nora's clarinet rental, $34 a month, which you look at for a long time on the statement, because it's the smallest number on the page and the only one you'd fight for.

You get an offer. Dispatch supervisor at a regional carrier. $58,000 a year. It's the company that took your biggest client. You sit in the Camry in their parking lot for a long time. Then you go in and sign.

Elena takes on extra shifts at the clinic. She doesn't complain. That's what makes it hard. One night you find her at the kitchen table at 1 a.m. with a calculator and a legal pad, doing math you used to do on a whiteboard, and she looks up, and for a second you see that she's been scared for a year, alone, because you were too proud to let her be scared with you.

> **Rule five. At $4,600, you didn't lose your money. You lost the story you told yourself about why you had it.**

## Level six, $0

Not negative. Zero. Not the zero of a broke kid with nothing to lose. The zero of someone who remembers every number above it. That's a different kind of empty. It has an echo. You hit it on a Wednesday in November. The car insurance draft and the electric bill land on the same morning, and the account reads $0.00, exactly, like the universe has a sense of humor.

You drive Nora to school in the Camry. She's twelve now. She's quiet in the passenger seat, looking out the window, and then she says, out of nowhere, "Are we poor now?"

You don't answer right away. You think about the seven keys. The booth under the brass lamp. The golf trip. The host who knew your name. You think about everything that left, in the order it left, and you realize you can name every single thing you lost and you cannot remember the last time you asked her about the water filter.

"We don't have much money right now," you say. "That's different."

"How's it different?"

You pull into the drop-off line. You turn and look at her. Really look. She's got Elena's eyes and your father's chin and a mechanical pencil behind her ear.

"Ask me about your science project," you say. "The water one. From last year."

She frowns. "That was forever ago. Why?"

"Because I wasn't listening. Tell me again."

And she does. Sand, gravel, cotton, charcoal. Dirty water in the top, clean water out the bottom. She talks for four minutes, and the car behind you honks, and you don't move, and she doesn't stop, and it's the longest anyone in your family has talked to you in a year.

> **Rule six. At $0, you find out what was never on the balance sheet. And it was the only thing that ever compounded.**

## Outro

Somewhere tonight, someone at $3.8 million is hanging a new key on a steel ring. A second boat, maybe. A ski condo. They feel the weight of it in their pocket at dinner, under a brass lamp, where the host knows their name. Their phone buzzes with plans, not problems. Their kid is talking across the table about something they built. They're nodding. They're checking a score.

They think the keys are the life. They're not. They're just doors. And the most expensive thing you'll ever own is the one you don't notice until it stops opening.

You have one key now. Silver. Cheap. It snags on your pocket lining.

And for the first time in years, the people behind that door are waiting for you, not for what you're carrying.

### Closing question (voiceover + on-screen text)

**What did losing money teach you that having it never did? Tell me below. I read every one.**

## Script prompt

Copy everything below the divider line and paste it into any AI. To get a fresh variation, change the names, numbers, business and settings in the INPUTS block.

Backup title if the main one is taken on YouTube: "From $3.8 Million to $0: What Leaves First".

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You are a scriptwriter for Somber Journal, a faceless YouTube channel that tells money stories in 2D animation. The channel is about how money quietly changes the way people treat you. It gives no financial advice and no how-to steps. Write ONE complete, original, voiceover-ready script.

#### INPUTS

- Title: What Losing Everything Looks Like, Level by Level
- Format: a Level Ladder that goes DOWN, 6 levels
- Target length: 2,450 words (stay within ±5%), about 16 minutes at 150 wpm
- Levels: $3.8 million · $900,000 · $210,000 · $38,000 · $4,600 · $0
- The protagonist (never named, never gendered) owns Kessler Freight: 42 trucks, 91 employees. One national home-goods retailer is 64% of revenue. A $1.4M line of credit is personally guaranteed.
- Cast (first names only):
  - Elena: spouse, a clinic worker, notices everything, says little
  - Nora: daughter, 11 then 12, built a water filter from a two-liter bottle and sand for a science fair; plays clarinet
  - Graham: the relationship banker
  - Hector: a driver since the second truck, laid off at Level 2
  - Brent: a friend from the club
  - Dad: 74, drives a 2004 Silverado with a tape deck
  - The host at Marlow's steakhouse, who knows your name

## CORE IDEA

Money doesn't leave all at once. It leaves in the order you stopped paying attention. As each thing goes, you learn who was calling the money and who was calling you. At zero, you find the one thing that was never on the balance sheet: your daughter, and the fact that you never listened to her.

## RECURRING MOTIFS (PAY OFF EVERY ONE)

1. The key ring. Level 1 has seven keys: office, warehouse, the house on Linden Court, the lake house, the boat, the Range Rover, and a brass key to a closet safe. Remove one or more on screen at each level. At the end, one cheap silver rental key is left, "cut so roughly it snags on your pocket lining".
2. Marlow's steakhouse. Level 1: the host says your name and your corner booth under the brass lamp has your wine already poured. Level 3: "a lovely table by the window". Level 4: a new host asks for your name and a reservation. You realise you never learned the old host's name.
3. Nora's water filter. Level 1: she describes it at dinner while you check a game score. Level 6: you ask her to tell you about it again.
4. Phone calls: plans become reviews, then pauses, then nothing. The calls that remain are the ones that were about you.

## LEVEL BLUEPRINT

- Level 1, $3.8M: the keys pressing into your leg ("the only part of the money you can actually touch"), Marlow's at 8:14 on a Thursday, calls offering plans not problems, the dangerous 64% client "because easy pays", Elena noticing you're not listening to Nora. Thesis within the first 250 words: "Money doesn't leave all at once. It leaves in the order you stopped paying attention." Rule: "you don't have money. You have momentum."
- Level 2, $900,000: a 6:02 a.m. email titled "Strategic Vendor Consolidation" with 90 days' notice, math in the shower, the guarantee you signed "like a birthday card". The boat is sold for $118,000 and its key comes off. You lay off 22 drivers yourself; Hector says "You'll be all right, boss." The glass-room review with Graham and an unnamed younger man, and "covenant ratio". Sitting in the garage listening to Nora's clarinet crack on the same note. Elena passes you salt you didn't ask for. Rule: "you didn't lose money. You lost the right to be careless."
- Level 3, $210,000: a bank letter with "regrettably", the lake house sold (keep the dock lights on a 7 p.m. timer that Nora used to watch), the window table at Marlow's, the golf trip going ahead without you. Brent offers a $450-an-hour consultant and asks about the club party with a telling pause ("There is always pressure in 'no pressure.'").

The $14,800 membership lapses and nobody calls. Elena in bed: "how bad is it?" Rule: "you're the person everyone's waiting to hear about."

- Level 4, $38,000: the company closes and the last trucks are hauled away with your name on the doors (callback to painting the first truck in your father's driveway with a cereal-box stencil). Office and warehouse keys come off. The Range Rover becomes a $7,300 Camry; Nora asks "Is it a rental?" and says "Oh." The new host at Marlow's. Dad offers his truck and talks about the weather for 20 minutes to keep you company. Hector at a gas station asks about everyone by name and never about money: "You still got my number, boss." Rule: "you find out who was calling the money, and who was calling you."
- Level 5, $4,600: Linden Court is sold and you move to an east-side rental with a ticking ceiling fan; Nora gets the bigger room. Two keys left. Job interviews where they wonder what went wrong with you. A grocery and bills breakdown where the $34-a-month clarinet rental is "the only one you'd fight for". You take a $58,000 dispatch job at the company that took your client. Elena at 1 a.m. with a calculator, scared alone for a year because you were too proud. Rule: "you didn't lose your money. You lost the story you told yourself about why you had it."
- Level 6, $0: the account reads exactly $0.00 on a Wednesday in November, "a zero with an echo". In the school drop-off line, Nora asks "Are we poor now?" Answer: "We don't have much money right now. That's different." Then: "Ask me about your science project... Because I wasn't listening. Tell me again." She talks for four minutes, the car behind honks, you don't move. Rule: "you find out what was never on the balance sheet. And it was the only thing that ever compounded."

## OUTRO

"Somewhere tonight, someone at $3.8 million is hanging a new key on a steel ring..." Replay Level 1 in third person: the brass lamp, a host who knows their name, a kid talking about something they built while the parent checks a score. Then: the keys are just doors, and the most expensive thing you own is the one you don't notice until it stops opening. Close on the single silver key and on the people behind that door "waiting for you, not for what you're carrying".

## VOICE AND STYLE

- Second person, present tense, 100% of the time. The protagonist is never named. Supporting characters always get first names.
- The narrator is calm, intimate and slightly clinical. Warm toward people, cold toward systems: banks never yell, they send letters.
- Name the missing or unexpected feeling, never the obvious one ("You notice that you notice.").

- Mostly short sentences of 4–10 words and fragments. Every 5–7 lines, add one long cascading sentence of 25–40 words joined with "and..., and..., and...".
- Use negation runs ("Not bankruptcy, not yet. Just closed."). End most paragraphs on a 3–6 word punch.
- Numbers are always exact and slightly odd ($118,000, $1,940 a month, 6:02 a.m.).
- Drop a quotable line every 150–230 words that could stand alone as a clip.
- Each level ends with a spoken verdict: "Rule [N]. At $[amount], ___."
- Include at least one tender, unspoken-love moment per level from Dad, Hector or Elena, and at least one moment where the protagonist sees their own pride as the problem.
- The ending is hopeful but earned: no rescue, no comeback money.
- The ONLY direct question to the viewer is the closing comment question (see OUTPUT). No intro, no "welcome back", no channel name, no call to subscribe, no advice, no headings, no emojis, no scene directions.

## OUTPUT

1. First line: "TARGET: 2,450 words".
2. The full script as plain paragraphs, voiceover-ready.
3. After the final thesis line, end with this exact closing comment question as its own paragraph: "What did losing money teach you that having it never did? Tell me below. I read every one."
4. Last line: "FINAL: [N] words · est. runtime [N/150] min".

# 4. Channel branding: Somber Journal

Replaces "Somber Code". Before switching, check on YouTube that the handle and name are free.

## Name and handle

- **Channel name:** Somber Journal
- **Handle, in order of preference:** @SomberJournal · @TheSomberJournal · @SomberJournalTV
- **Fallback name if taken:** Somber Diary

## Tagline (banner, description, end of every video description)

**The money stories nobody tells you.**

Alternatives:

- Money changes everything. Quietly.
- What money does to the people around you.

## Channel description: final (recommended)

The money stories nobody tells you.

Somber Journal is animated storytelling about how money quietly changes your life, and the people in it.

Every story is told to you, about you. What your family stops telling you at every level of wealth. What leaves first when you lose everything. Why two friends with the same paycheck end up living two completely different lives. How banks, landlords and the people you love see you differently at −$3,000 and at $10 million.

No get-rich-quick. No gurus. No financial advice. Just honest stories about money, family, pride, and what it costs to climb or to fall.

New stories every week. Subscribe if you've ever felt the number in your account change the way people look at you.

All stories are fiction. Characters are composites and numbers are illustrative.

## Channel description: short version (About preview, social bios)

The money stories nobody tells you. Animated stories about how money quietly changes your life, and the people in it. No advice, just the truth you feel but never hear out loud. New stories every week.

## Video description template (paste under every upload)

[One-sentence hook from the video, e.g. "At negative $3,140, your family worries about you. At $10 million, they stop telling you anything."]

[Two sentences on the story, no spoilers for the ending.]

Somber Journal: the money stories nobody tells you.

[Closing comment question from the script]

This story is fiction. The characters are composites and the numbers are illustrative.

#money #wealth #personalfinance #storytime #animation

## Channel keywords (YouTube Studio → Settings → Channel → Keywords)

money stories, wealth psychology, every level of wealth, money and family, personal finance stories, animated money stories, rich vs poor, financial storytelling, money mindset, Somber Journal

## Logo prompt: Option 1, the journal (recommended)

Circular YouTube profile avatar, flat 2D cartoon illustration with bold clean outlines and soft cel shading. A closed, worn leather journal in deep navy, seen at a slight three-quarter angle, held shut by a thin elastic band. A single muted-gold ribbon bookmark hangs from the bottom, and its tip is shaped like a small coin. A soft warm glow behind the journal, as if from a desk lamp, on a dark charcoal background. Minimal detail, centered composition, high contrast, crisp and readable at small sizes, calm and melancholic mood, no text.

## Logo prompt: Option 2, monogram

Circular YouTube profile avatar, minimalist flat design. The letters "SJ" in an elegant serif typeface, muted gold on a deep navy circle, with a thin hairline ring inside the edge. A tiny ribbon bookmark hangs from the bottom of the "J". Subtle paper texture, high contrast, crisp and readable at small sizes, quiet and premium mood.

## Banner prompts (v2, built on your existing character and wordmark)

AI image tools often garble text. Generate the art **without text** using Prompt A or B, then add the wordmark and tagline yourself in Canva or Photoshop using the layout spec below. Prompt C is for tools that handle text well.

**Character reference (keep identical everywhere):** a young adult with messy, curly black hair, a black hoodie with the hood up, thick black rectangular glasses, tired half-lidded eyes, a slight flat frown, a deadpan, worn-out expression. Bold clean black outlines, flat 2D cartoon style, mostly grayscale.

### Prompt A: character at the desk (recommended)

YouTube channel banner background, 2560×1440, flat 2D cartoon illustration with bold clean black outlines and soft cel shading, mostly grayscale with a single warm accent. Near-black background (#121214) with a soft dark vignette at the edges. Left of center, inside the middle third of the image: a young adult with messy curly black hair, a black hoodie with the hood up, thick black rectangular glasses, tired half-lidded eyes and a slight flat frown, sitting at a small table late at night and writing in an open dark-navy journal. A single warm hanging lamp above them casts a soft amber glow (#E8B86B) on their face, hands and the pages. On the table: a coffee mug, a folded bill and two crumpled receipts. The right half of the center area is empty dark space reserved for text. Quiet, intimate, melancholic mood. All important content within the central 1546×423 area. No text, no logos, no buttons.

### Prompt B: minimal portrait

YouTube channel banner background, 2560×1440, near-black background (#121214) with a subtle film-grain texture and a soft dark vignette. Left of center, inside the middle third of the image: a large circular portrait in flat 2D cartoon style with bold black outlines, mostly grayscale, of a young adult with messy curly black hair, a black hoodie with the hood up, thick black rectangular glasses, tired half-lidded eyes and a slight flat frown. A thin muted-gold ring (#C9A45C) around the circle, and a faint warm amber glow behind it as if from an off-screen lamp. The right half of the center area is empty dark space reserved for text. Minimal, premium, melancholic mood. No text, no logos, no buttons.

### Prompt C: all in one (only for tools that render text reliably)

Same as Prompt A, plus: on the right side of the central area, the words "somber journal" in lowercase white, with "somber" in a heavy geometric sans-serif and "journal" in a thin light sans-serif; below it a thin muted-gold line (#C9A45C); below that the tagline "The money stories nobody tells you." in small letter-spaced off-white sans-serif; and below that, smaller and dimmer, "New stories every week". No subscribe button.

### Layout spec for adding text in Canva or Photoshop

- **Canvas:** 2560 × 1440 px. Keep all text and the character inside the central 1546 × 423 safe zone (x 507–2053, y 508–931).
- **Wordmark:** keep your current one. "somber" in Montserrat ExtraBold (or Poppins Bold); "journal" in Montserrat Light / Thin. White (#F2EEE6). About 150–170 px tall.
- **Gold line:** 2 px, muted gold (#C9A45C), the same width as the wordmark, 20 px below it.
- **Tagline:** "The money stories nobody tells you." in Montserrat Regular, 44–48 px, letter-spacing +8%, off-white.
- **Small line:** "New stories every week" in Montserrat Regular, 30 px, 60% opacity.
- **Remove:** the Subscribe button.
- **Check:** preview with YouTube's banner tool on mobile, desktop and TV before saving.

## Video watermark (YouTube Studio → Customization → Branding)

A simplified version of the logo journal icon, white on transparent, 150×150 px. Show it for the entire video.

## Brand palette

| Role | Colour | Hex |
|---|---|---|
| Primary background | Deep navy | #1E2A3A |
| Secondary | Charcoal | #2B2B30 |
| Accent | Muted gold | #C9A45C |
| Warm light | Lamp amber | #E8B86B |
| Text | Off-white | #F2EEE6 |

## Switching checklist

1. Check that @SomberJournal is free on YouTube.
2. YouTube Studio → Customization → Basic info: change the name, the handle and the description.
3. Upload the new logo, banner and watermark.
4. Add the channel keywords.
5. Update the pinned comment and descriptions on videos 1 and 2 with the new tagline.
6. Publish video 3 under the new name. The handle change keeps the same channel, subscribers and videos.